

Latest update

The 2026-27 BMSB season commences 1 September 2026.

All roll-on roll-off (RoRo) vessels will be issued a Seasonal Pest Questionnaire (SPQ) up until 30 June 2027 to accommodate sailing times from target risk countries. Vessel masters must complete the questionnaire to support the department's assessment of seasonal pest risk.

The SPQ assists in:

- Confirming whether the vessel has visited a target risk country during the brown marmorated stink bug (BMSB) risk season.
- Determining whether the vessel is carrying cargo loaded in any target risk countries visited since its last voyage to Australia.
- Supporting the early identification of pests detected or collected aboard the vessel prior to arrival in Australia.

Seasonal measures apply to all roll-on roll-off (Ro-Ro) vessels that berth at, load or tranship in target risk countries between 1 September and 30 April inclusive.

The seasonal measures enable the department to:

- Improve the department's ability to assess seasonal pest risks on vessels prior to arrival.
- Enhance the ability for all parties to manage risks offshore, at berth and onshore.
- Improve the effectiveness and timeliness of BMSB mitigation activities.

The list of target risk countries for the BMSB risk season is available on our [Seasonal measures for Brown marmorated stink bug \(BMSB\)](#) webpage.

Vessel surveillance for specified vessel types

Between 1 September and 30 June (inclusive) all Ro-Ro vessels are sent a Seasonal Pest Questionnaire (SPQ) as part of their pre-arrival reporting.

Ro-Ro vessels that have berthed at, loaded or transhipped cargo from target risk countries will be directed to perform a crew vessel inspection. A crew vessel inspection is an inspection performed by the ship's crew of the vessel and its cargo for hitchhiker pests. All findings must be reported via the mandatory SPQ.

Other vessels must report the detection of any insects as part of their ordinary pre-arrival reporting. When BMSB or other actionable exotic species are reported, the vessels will be directed to perform a crew vessel inspection.

Mandated seasonal pest inspections for Ro-Ro vessels from target risk countries

Ro-Ro vessels that have berthed, loaded or transhipped from target risk countries will be subject to a mandatory seasonal pest (SP) inspection on arrival in Australian territory.

Seasonal pests, including BMSB, pose a high risk to Australia because of their tendency to hitchhike and their highly mobile nature. Between September and April, coinciding with late autumn and winter in the northern hemisphere, BMSB will seek shelter from cold weather in crevices or protected areas.

Ro-Ro vessel masters are required to confirm that a crew vessel inspection of their vessel has been completed prior to arriving in Australia. The purpose of this inspection is to detect any seasonal pests that may be on board.

Where to look

Seasonal pests are very small and may be hidden in hard to see places. Crew vessel inspections of vessels should include:

- All cargo holds/decks and adjoining stairwells
- The outside surface of shipping containers
- Inside and on the outside surface of machinery and vehicles (where possible)
- Near light sources.

Pre-arrival reporting assists the department to assess the condition of a vessel prior to its arrival in Australian territory. This reporting informs the department of any potential biosecurity risks that are associated with human, animal and plant health, goods and ballast water for each vessel during its voyage in Australia.

When to report

In accordance with section 193 of the Biosecurity Act 2015 (the Act), commercial vessel operators intending to enter Australian territory must report to the department between 96 and 12 hours before the vessel's estimated time of arrival in Australian waters.

Vessel masters are encouraged to submit their [Pre-Arrival Report](#) (PAR) as close as possible to 96 hours prior to arrival to avoid any delay in assessment of seasonal pest biosecurity risks.

Failure to give a report containing the information required may contravene subsection 193(4) of the Act.

How to submit a seasonal pest questionnaire

Once a Pre-Arrival Report (PAR) has been received through the [Maritime and Aircraft Reporting System](#) (MARS), all Ro-Ro vessels will be provided with a Seasonal Pest Questionnaire (SPQ) for completion.

All Ro-Ro vessels will be required to perform at least one crew vessel inspection. We recommend that this initial seasonal pest crew inspection be conducted between 72 and 24 hours prior to the submission of the PAR. Where insects are detected, the vessel will be required to perform two additional inspections over 48 hours.

Where insects are detected at any point in the voyage to Australia, vessel masters must provide details on their PAR and SPQ of the number of live and dead insects found, the deck and hold location where they were found and a detailed stowage plan.

Clear photos of all insects must be submitted along with the completed Seasonal Pest Questionnaire. The Seasonal Pest Questionnaire includes guidance on how to take photos of insects.

All insects must be kept refrigerated (NOT stored in the freezer) for presentation to a biosecurity officer on arrival in Australia.

Insects detected after submission of the SPQ must be reported via the National Maritime Centre via email maratimenc@aff.gov.au.

Seasonal pest inspections are different to a routine vessel inspection. For a seasonal pest inspection, a vessel's ramp and doors must remain closed (except to allow access for government officials). Cargo must not be discharged until the inspection has been completed and approval is granted.

If live insects, or a significant number of dead insects are detected, a seasonal pest inspection will be supplemented with inspection aide measures. This will require the application of thermal pyrethrum fogging and residual insecticide.

Seasonal pest inspections will only commence during daylight hours.

Further information

For further general information regarding BMSB seasonal measures, visit the [Seasonal Measures for BMSB webpage](#) or for policy questions email the Hitchhiker Pests and Ports Policy: HPP@aff.gov.au.

Information on pre-arrival reporting for maritime vessels can be found on the department's website under [Vessels](#), or by contacting the department's [National Maritime Centre](#) (NMC) by email or phone 1300 004 605 (in Australia) or +61 8 8201 6185 (outside Australia).

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/import/before/brown-marmorated-stink-bugs/vessels>